



Practical Report

2022 Stage 2 MW Exam

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Practical exam chair report, Peter Marks MW

What a difference a year makes! This year's practical exam results are much improved over the previous, pandemic-impacted year. Overall, 12 out of 90 total candidates successfully passed the practical exam resulting in a 13.3% pass rate, compared to 8 passes and an 8% pass rate in 2021. This aligned much closer with “normal” pass rates in recent years such as 15% in 2019 and 14% in 2018. While this is encouraging, there were no high pass marks, which demonstrates that one off-day will not ruin one's chances, but consistency is essential.

No doubt the better results reflected candidates' ability to attend in-person events such as IMW education seminars and course days, student organized tasting groups, trade tasting events and trips, while still making good use of the much-enhanced online training resources from the education committee. There is no substitute for rigorous tasting practice and the general impression is that candidates had the means to do so this year.

Candidates know that correct identification of wines is an important aspect of the exam, but getting close, even if wrong, by using accurate evidence from the glass and sound deductive reasoning can also earn strong marks. It is worth mentioning that approximately 46% of the marks across all three papers were for grape and/or origin identification. Thus, simply getting all the wines right will not result in a pass since 24% of the marks covered quality and maturity, 21% of the marks asked about winemaking and 9% were devoted to commercial potential.

The individual paper chairs have done an excellent analysis of each paper so I won't repeat what they have said but I will point out some common themes.

Across the board, this year candidates did a better job of recognising the wines when they came from so-called classic varieties and classic regions (e.g., Clare Valley Riesling, Chinon, and Tawny Port). Yet they struggled when the origins were more obscure or were made from neutral varieties. For these types of wines, there is a tendency for less successful candidates to go with their first impression based upon one or two pieces of evidence and then write an answer to fit that assumption. Better results can be achieved by taking a step back, considering all the relevant evidence from the glass and then using deductive reasoning (funneling) to consider a few options. This allows the examiner to see your logic and award marks even if your conclusion is incorrect.

The ability to identify classic wines is most likely why paper two had the largest number of passes (22) and highest overall average since this paper featured many such wines. It was followed by paper three (12 passes) and paper one (11 passes), both of which presented more challenging wines. This reinforces why candidates need a better strategy when faced with lesser known or more neutral wines, and the importance of completing good answers on all parts of the question besides identification.

Because 54% of the exam was weighted on quality, maturity, winemaking, style and commercial potential, candidates need to perform well on these types of question to pass the exam. Too often the responses to these questions come up short by not providing enough evidence or failing to convincingly prove your answer. To be a Master of Wine you need to have the ability to a) carefully read the question and heed the number of marks available, and b) know what relevant information and how much detail is necessary to answer the question. Often candidates fail because they lack the confidence to provide in-depth analysis and fail to persuade the examiner that they truly understand the wine. For example, examiners look for winemaking answers that mention concise fermentation temperatures or discuss not only the type and size of oak used for maturation, but how long in oak and the percent of new oak used with evidence. Too many candidates use repetitive answers for commercial position questions without specifically relating the unique aspects of a given wine. Quality answers generally do refer well to BLIC or BLICCA (balance, length, intensity, complexity, concentration, age-worthiness) but they frequently lack confidence and play it safe by not truly getting "under the skin of the wine", which would show mastery.

On the plus side, time management was much improved this year with fewer questions left unanswered. Or, if a candidate was unsure of the wine's identity, they left this section blank and would still complete answers for quality, winemaking or commercial potential and earn valuable marks along the way. Nonetheless, students who failed to answer many of the questions received the lowest overall scores on the exam. Candidates should not waste an exam attempt if they have not put in the proper preparation and know how to manage their time.

Finally, all candidates are highly encouraged to read the practical exam guidelines, which are available on the IMW website. This document offers excellent advice on how to be successful in the practical exam. Should anyone have any further questions, please contact Sarah Harrison and she will forward your inquiry to the practical exam team.

Paper one report 2022: Paper chair, Peter Mitchell MW

General comments

This year candidates were much better prepared for paper one after the absence of the 2020 exam and the return of in-person education events. 12% of the papers received a passing mark compared with only 7% in 2021. After so many candidates struggled to finish paper one last year it was pleasing to see that there were few completely unanswered questions, which no doubt contributed to this year's improvement.

Paper one this year focused on quality, maturity, winemaking and market position. Whilst many of the wines in this paper were very distinctive and should have posed less of a challenge to identify, some provided greater challenges, and markers showed latitude on these wines for well-argued and logical conclusions that referred correctly to the elements of what was in the glass. I would once again emphasise that the argument is as important as the conclusion and is the key to passing identification questions.

Whilst there were fewer incidences of candidates not reading the question this year, there were still a number who had not heeded previous advice and we saw answers with wines 1 and 2 coming from different vintages and a number who neglected to answer all four elements asked for in question 1 b). There were also some who discussed blends in question 4. I can't stress enough how important it is to read the question carefully and fully.

At the risk of repeating my last report, there were once again many winemaking theory errors and far too many do not consider malolactic conversion and lees work when talking about white wines. Their absence is as much of a winemaking choice as their presence.

Properly answering questions about maturity continues to be a struggle for a significant number. To gain full marks, it is essential you state how old the wine is (including vintage if appropriate), where it is in its evolution currently and how it will develop in the future.

Market position questions were generally answered much more thoughtfully this year, with most candidates referring to domestic and export potential as well as the channel the wine would be most suited to. A few answers still majored on food pairing which is not what is being asked for.

The examiners' reports have, for several years now, had a repeated theme regarding quality assessments lacking context and the overuse of 'premium' or 'good' without any context. It was pleasing therefore to see the vast majority seemed to have taken this on board, with very few answers not making clear where the candidate felt the wine sat in the market or against its peers.

Question 1

Opening with a classic region and two wines from the same vintage and producer, for the better candidates this was relatively straightforward. Virtually all candidates were in Burgundy with most in the Côte d'Or, although the firm acidity of wine 2 did lead some to Chablis. A significant number struggled with wine 2, missing the weight, power and length and assessing it as the lesser of the two wines. Wine 1 was a high-quality example and undoubtedly more upfront, open and expressive on the

nose, but this exuberance should not have overshadowed the concentration, complexity and quality which the very youthful wine 2 had in abundance. Getting the quality wrong did not preclude good marks on part b), especially for those who had assessed both as high quality.

Question 2

This was well answered with the vast majority of candidates identifying this as a flight from Australia, but few articulated *why* the flight was from Australia, instead answering the identification part as if the country was given. Examiners expected to see some justification for the country as well as the region within. Almost all identified the Riesling correctly, both variety and origin and also the variety of the Chardonnay. Most also identified the origin as Margaret River, although good marks could be achieved for other regions within Australia if well argued. Although Wine 5 had coincidentally featured in the residential seminars this year, it still caused more challenges with the majority going for Semillon. Good marks could be achieved for this depending on the origin, but many having guessed Hunter Semillon erroneously talked about low alcohol and high acidity as a justification, neither of which were accurate. The obvious bottle age on wine 5 was well commented on and maturity in general very well answered. The very high quality of wine 4 was very well identified, wine 3 less frequently, whilst the winemaking was either very well or very poorly answered – I refer to my comments in the introduction.

Question 3

This was the most challenging flight in the exam and tested the breadth of candidates' knowledge of styles and their ability to draw logical conclusions. The examiners awarded a much higher proportion of the marks available for identification for the argument rather than for the conclusion.

The Gewurztraminer was generally well spotted, but perhaps a gap in knowledge of styles and where the variety is grown led many to Alsace which then left them looking for homes in France for wines 6 and 8.

Good candidates did not panic and described the wines' structures and characters well, drawing reasonable conclusions. Too many made a wild guess and then wrote an answer to fit their guess that did not reflect how the wine had tasted. The second part of the question was answered better, although some of the wilder guesses in part a) led to poor style and quality assessments.

Question 4

A classic mixed bag which produced some very well-articulated and accurate answers. The Torrontes was a benchmark example and the best answered wine on the paper with several candidates earning the full 25 marks. The Albariño was a very high-quality example and the majority spotted this. A number thought this was Grüner-Veltliner, which had a knock-on effect with the following wine, although marks could still be earned for the quality assessment and market position parts of the question. The Grüner-Veltliner was also generally well answered, both for identification and quality. The St.Péray Roussanne was more of a challenge with very few correctly identifying it. This was a very high-quality wine and Condrieu and Viognier were the most common misidentifications, where

high marks could still be earned. Less successful were a minority who went for moderate quality California Chardonnay.

Paper two report 2022: Paper Chair, Lisa Perrotti-Brown MW

General comments

Each year the practical exam committee goes to great lengths and spends considerable time sourcing wines that represent different origins, styles, and quality levels to produce a paper that is both fair and challenging. This year, judging by some of the high-caliber candidate performances and the number of passes (23% success rate), I believe we achieved that. While some of the paper two wines were arguably straightforward to identify, it is essential to bear in mind that the identification in these cases was only a small portion of the marks. Far more valuable for our industry is the ability to evaluate quality accurately (regardless of price or regionally designated position, e.g., Grand Cru Classé), recognise detectable winemaking methods, describe the style, and discuss market position/potential. The best candidates rose to this challenge admirably, demonstrating significant tasting experience, for which no amount of theoretical learning can be a substitute.

Question 1

Question 1 was an unconventional question designed to have students think about why single variety vs. blended wines exist, using Bordeaux varieties and the classic Bordeaux blend. For the first three wines, apart from grape and region identifications, candidates were asked to “Comment on the style, considering possible reasons for not blending the variety used for this wine.” There were numerous ways of answering this for each wine. For the Chinon, we were looking for justifications such as “It’s a style embraced for purity, freshness, lively acid, and the use of a single variety is traditional, and in this case enshrined by law.” For the Napa Cabernet, the answer could have been, “This is a complete, high quality, balanced, and age-worthy Cabernet Sauvignon with no need to blend to address ripeness shortcomings.” The Chilean Merlot could have been a little trickier to identify and justify, so a certain amount of leeway was given. For this, marketing/variety labeling could have been used as a justification, given its commercial style and lower-quality aspirations. For the fourth wine, the Bordeaux blend from Pessac-Léognan, to pick up full points, there must have been a sum greater than the parts argument, with reference to each variety and the part it plays in the wine. Candidates could have referred to the attributes of the three previous wines or picked out each grape’s characteristics as seen in wine 4. So, there was some flexibility with how this last question of the first flight could have been tackled.

Question 2

This question (and its twin, question 3) was much more of a straightforward identification question, although many of the points were awarded for the commentary on style and quality. It was a little disappointing how many students did not go to Tuscany for these wines when this region is of such paramount importance, and these two wines were classic examples. To get full points on the identification part of this question, candidates had to be in Tuscany, although some points were allowed for Piedmont. The winemaking, quality and style parts of this question were generally well managed, with most candidates recognizing the Brunello as higher quality.

Question 3

Question 3 was the same as 2 but with different wines. Most students were in Burgundy for this pair but needed to be more accurate with their quality assessments. Burgundy remains a critical benchmark region, and candidates must have considerable experience tasting this region's wines at all quality levels to understand the differences.

Questions 4 & 5

Questions 4 and 5 were similar questions with the same marks for two different pairs of typical, well-known grapes and regions. Surprisingly, many students failed to identify the grapes and regions correctly. The Argentine Malbec pair had a higher pass rate, with the best candidates correctly identifying the grapes and quality differences. However, answers varied widely for the last pair of Zinfandels. The classic mistake here was to focus too much on the overt use of American oak on both Zinfandels, inspiring a lot of candidates to try to shoe-horn the wines into Rioja. Apart from the American oak, there is nothing remotely Rioja-like about these two wines. Some candidates went to Barossa and Grenache, which did pick up some points. In short, California Zinfandel remains a must-know, and a pair of classic examples like this should not throw candidates off. This said, the style and quality parts of these questions were generally well answered and saved some candidates who failed to correctly identify the wines.

Paper three report 2022: Paper Chair, Ulf Sjodin MW

This year's practical paper three proved to be something of a challenge for candidates with only 12% of the papers receiving a passing mark. Some of the wines (W2, the Lambrusco; W7, the South African Chenin Blanc and W12, the Tawny from Australia) presented greater challenges, with few candidates arriving at a correct identification. The examiners were conscious of the difficulty with these wines and reasonable arguments for other origins were given good marks. Conversely, there were four wines that almost every candidate identified correctly.

The point which candidates should remember is that the paper tests their wine production and style knowledge. Therefore, it is important to learn how certain wines are made and to draw conclusions from accurate tasting, especially of structural elements such as alcohol and sugar levels. In a number of cases candidates identified the wine incorrectly and then put in figures of alcohol and sugar to match, rather than assess the evidence in the glass and come to a logical outcome.

For W7, any botrytis wine with moderate alcohol levels was rewarded. Since the most classic alternatives, Tokaji and Sauternes, were present in the same flight, we saw some beautiful answers using this knowledge to exclude France and Hungary from the list of possible origins. On the other hand, too many students lacked the ability to correctly identify the alcohol and acidity levels and tried to match the arguments with their guess.

The examiners are looking for a conclusion based on a logical assessment of the elements of the wine. Therefore, statements such as 'A VDN with an alcohol of 20%' cannot earn points and is illogical. The alcohol assessment was correct, but the conclusion was incorrect. 'the wine is Champagne with an alcohol level of 14%' is again incorrect.

Other examples of a lack of wine making knowledge: 'Sherry made with 77% Brandy Alcohol'; '15 years Old Tawny Port'; 'The wine has 70 g residual sugar and is therefore a Beerenauslese' and finally "A sweet Amarone" for W10.

Wine 5 confused many candidates who were otherwise displaying accurate assessments. Residual sugar levels were estimated in the range from 12g to 90g, and alcohol levels from around 8% to 16%. If candidates concentrate on the analysis and then draw a logical conclusion, the marks given will be higher. The old saying that you should trust your first impression was proven wrong with this wine.

Wine 1, the Prosecco; W3, the Champagne; W6, the German Spätlese and W11, the Tawny Port were all identified by most candidates. The answers were generally very good, but a number of candidates could have scored higher marks by describing the production process in a more logical manner, from reception to bottling, so as not to miss out key points.

One example is the fact that many candidates missed out the fact that the base wine for Champagne is a blend of varieties, reserve wines etc. A simple and widely known element of production but one key to the style of the wine.

For winemaking questions, candidates should spend a minute thinking about the most important questions to answer. For the rosé flight, students who forgot to describe how the colour was achieved lost important marks. For all sweet wines we expected candidates to answer how fermentation was

stopped. Cooling? Fortification? Naturally? The answer “fermentation was stopped at 7% abv and 70 grams of residual sugar” would get more marks if a short sentence about how this was done was added.

Showing knowledge of classic wine making regions is an important part of all practical papers. Although W6 was identified as a German Spätlese by most students, most argued for a Mosel rather than the correct Rheingau. If argued well, students could still get all but one mark, but too many just stated Mosel without considering anything else, and with the low alcohol and high sugar as the only argument. This gives the examiners a reason to suspect that the student knows of nothing else than Mosel and as a consequence less marks will be awarded.

The question for the final flight stated that the wines were from different countries, yet a number of candidates still offered up both Port and Madeira in their answer. Since this was a rare mistake on Q1 and Q2, where similar background information was given, we suspect that not all students are aware that Madeira is a part of Portugal.

On a positive note, there were fewer cases of candidates running out of time and, in most instances, we saw a good recognition of classic wines. A number of candidates were close but require an improved exam technique, (i.e., writing sound and logical answers based on good tasting analysis) to pass. It should be remembered that, even when the identification of a grape variety or origin is wrong, if the tasting analysis is strong and the answer is logical, points can be given.

Quality assessment was also generally on a higher level than past years. The point of these answers is to position the wine on a quality ladder relevant to the origin. Most students managed to express that position rather well, in some cases using both a quality statement and a price point.

Commercial position was also well answered by many students, and the best answers considered domestic against international appeal, on trade versus off trade, supermarkets versus specialists, summer versus winter, etc. However, there were some students who only seemed to know the on trade, and never considered anything outside of the restaurant business. Food pairings were not uncommon but are rarely rewarded with any marks except on questions where a higher number of marks are available.